

Scrapbooking with Grandma

CHRISTMAS CARD STYLE GUIDE

What makes a card traditional, modern, vintage, rustic, elegant, whimsical - and everything in between

MORE ORNAMENT • WARMTH • HISTORY

MORE SPACE • SIMPLICITY • CONTRAST



COLOR	IMAGERY	TYPE
LAYOUT	TEXTURE	DETAIL

A practical reference for cardmaking, scrapbook pages, videos and printable collections

How to Read a Card's Style

A card is rarely modern or traditional because of one item. Its style comes from a group of visual choices working together.

STYLE SIGNAL	MORE TRADITIONAL	MORE MODERN
Color	Deep red, evergreen, cream, gold	Limited palette, unexpected colors, black/white contrast
Imagery	Holly, bells, wreaths, poinsettias, detailed scenes	One simplified tree, star, line-art wreath or geometric motif
Typography	Serif, script, calligraphy, decorative lettering	Clean sans serif, bold type, generous letter spacing
Layout	Centered, symmetrical, framed and layered	Asymmetrical, cropped, oversized and spacious
Texture	Ribbon, lace, embossing, distressing, many papers	Smooth cardstock, flat layers, one controlled texture
Embellishment	Full clusters and repeated decorative details	One focal piece with two or three tiny supporting accents

The quickest style test

- Cover half the embellishments with your hand. If the card suddenly feels more modern, density was the strongest traditional signal.
- Change only the palette. Deep red and green usually feel classic; navy and pink or black and gold feel more contemporary.
- Change only the typography. A clean sans serif can update even very traditional holly or bell imagery.
- Look at empty space. Modern cards usually let the eye rest; traditional and scrapbook-layered cards often celebrate abundance.

Important: modern does not mean plain, and traditional does not mean old-fashioned. Both can be detailed, beautiful and current. The difference is how the details are edited and arranged.

Christmas Card Style Library

Traditional / Classic 			
Overall feeling: Warm, familiar, celebratory and timeless			
PALETTE	Deep red, evergreen, cream, gold	IMAGERY	Holly, bells, wreaths, stockings, ornaments, plaid, poinsettias
TYPE	Serif, script or traditional hand-lettering	LAYOUT	Balanced or symmetrical; layered focal cluster
MATERIALS	Plaid paper, velvet-look ribbon, gold foil, greenery	GOOD FOLDS	Gatefold, easel, joy fold
CLUSTER RECIPE	Goldbells + red bow + holly		
MAKE IT MORE MODERN		Use one classic motif, fewer layers and more open space.	
MAKE IT MORE TRADITIONAL		Add plaid, ribbon, greenery, gold trim and a fuller cluster.	

Modern Minimalist 			
Overall feeling: Clean, calm, confident and uncluttered			
PALETTE	White plus 1-2 strong colors; black accents	IMAGERY	Single tree, star, line-art wreath, geometric snowflake
TYPE	Clean sans serif with generous letter spacing	LAYOUT	Asymmetrical or centered; abundant negative space
MATERIALS	Smooth cardstock, one foil detail, flat layers	GOOD FOLDS	Simple Z-fold, diagonal gatefold, flat A2
CLUSTER RECIPE	Onetree+ three tiny stars		
MAKE IT MORE MODERN		Limit the palette, motif count and embellishment depth.	
MAKE IT MORE TRADITIONAL		Introduce a serif sentiment, warmer color and a small holly accent.	

Christmas Card Style Library

Vintage / Nostalgic



Overall feeling: Collected, sentimental and story-rich

PALETTE	Faded red, olive, aged cream, muted blue	IMAGERY	Old ornaments, postage marks, music paper, Santa, lace, postcards
TYPE	Decorative serif, typewriter or antique script	LAYOUT	Layered collage with distressed edges
MATERIALS	Ink distressing, lace, doilies, torn paper, ephemera	GOOD FOLDS	Joy fold, buckle card, easel
CLUSTER RECIPE	Tag+postage shapes + holly + ribbon		

MAKE IT MORE MODERN

Use one vintage image on a clean neutral base.

MAKE IT MORE TRADITIONAL

Layer several papers, lace, inked edges and ephemera.

Rustic / Farmhouse



Overall feeling: Cozy, handmade, natural and relaxed

PALETTE	Kraft, barn red, pine green, black, cream	IMAGERY	Pinecones, woodland trees, berries, buffalo plaid, woodgrain
TYPE	Simple serif, typewriter or casual hand-lettering	LAYOUT	Informal layers; grounded horizontal clusters
MATERIALS	Kraft paper, burlap, twine, gingham, wood texture	GOOD FOLDS	Bridge fold, gatefold, center-step
CLUSTER RECIPE	Pinesprigs + pinecone + burlap bow		

MAKE IT MORE MODERN

Pair kraft with black-and-white graphics and simple shapes.

MAKE IT MORE TRADITIONAL

Add burlap, red plaid, berries and fuller greenery.

Christmas Card Style Library

Elegant / Luxe 			
Overall feeling: Formal, luminous and special-occasion			
PALETTE	Cream, white, gold, silver, deep green, navy	IMAGERY	Filigree snowflakes, ornate ornaments, bows, delicate foliage
TYPE	High-contrast serif or graceful script	LAYOUT	Centered, symmetrical and carefully spaced
MATERIALS	Foil, pearl, shimmer cardstock, satin ribbon, embossing	GOOD FOLDS	Easel, twisted easel, gatefold
CLUSTER RECIPE	Creambow + gold ornament + pearl accents		
MAKE IT MORE MODERN		Use matte white, one metallic and a refined silhouette.	
MAKE IT MORE TRADITIONAL		Add ornate borders, layered ribbon and multiple metallic details.	

Whimsical / Playful 			
Overall feeling: Cheerful, energetic and full of personality			
PALETTE	Bright red, lime, pink, aqua, candy colors	IMAGERY	Curly trees, candy canes, smiling characters, wonky stars, gifts
TYPE	Rounded, bouncy or hand-drawn lettering	LAYOUT	Angled layers, movement, varied scale and playful repetition
MATERIALS	Polka dots, stripes, glitter, pom-poms, bright ribbon	GOOD FOLDS	Pop-up box, waterfall, side-opening Z-fold
CLUSTER RECIPE	Candycanes + bow + peppermint + curls		
MAKE IT MORE MODERN		Use bold flat shapes and a controlled bright palette.	
MAKE IT MORE TRADITIONAL		Add more patterned paper, glitter and layered accents.	

Christmas Card Style Library

Nordic / Scandinavian 			
Overall feeling: Simple, cozy, crafted and wintery			
PALETTE	Red, white, soft gray, natural wood; sometimes navy	IMAGERY	Folk stars, hearts, simple trees, reindeer, knitted patterns
TYPE	Clean sans serif or simple folk lettering	LAYOUT	Orderly repetition, borders, rows and centered motifs
MATERIALS	Matte paper, stitched details, woodgrain, woven patterns	GOOD FOLDS	Z-fold, gatefold, simple easel
CLUSTER RECIPE	Folksnowflake + heart + pine sprig		
MAKE IT MORE MODERN		Keep motifs geometric with lots of white space.	
MAKE IT MORE TRADITIONAL		Use repeated folk borders, red-and-white patterns and stitching.	

Botanical / Nature 			
Overall feeling: Fresh, peaceful, organic and refined			
PALETTE	Layered greens, berry red, cream, brown, touches of gold	IMAGERY	Pine, cedar, eucalyptus, holly, berries, pinecones
TYPE	Quiet serif, light sans serif or restrained script	LAYOUT	Crescents, wreaths, corner sprays and flowing diagonals
MATERIALS	Watercolor paper, vellum, natural twine, textured cardstock	GOOD FOLDS	Bridge fold, diagonal gatefold, center-step
CLUSTER RECIPE	Mixedgreenery + berries + one bell		
MAKE IT MORE MODERN		Choose airy foliage and a narrow, tonal palette.	
MAKE IT MORE TRADITIONAL		Use dense evergreen, holly, red berries and a full bow.	

Christmas Card Style Library

Religious / Nativity 			
Overall feeling: Reverent, peaceful, hopeful and meaningful			
PALETTE	Midnight blue, cream, gold, white, muted earth tones	IMAGERY	Nativity, Bethlehem star, angels, doves, candles, sacred text
TYPE	Classic serif, calligraphy or simple elegant lettering	LAYOUT	Strong central image, radiant star or quiet silhouette
MATERIALS	Gold foil, vellum, deep cardstock, subtle shimmer	GOOD FOLDS	Easel, gatefold, center-step
CLUSTER RECIPE	Goldstar+ navy layers + subtle foliage		
MAKE IT MORE MODERN		Use a simple silhouette, one star and quiet spacing.	
MAKE IT MORE TRADITIONAL		Add ornate framing, layered gold, script and richer detail.	

Cute / Character 			
Overall feeling: Sweet, friendly and family-focused			
PALETTE	Clear bright colors or soft pastels	IMAGERY	Snowmen, gingerbread, penguins, gnomes, friendly Santa
TYPE	Rounded sans serif or playful handwritten style	LAYOUT	Large character focal point with small supporting accents
MATERIALS	Soft textures, faux stitching, dots, stripes, dimensional foam	GOOD FOLDS	Pop-up box, waterfall, Z-fold
CLUSTER RECIPE	Character+ tiny gift + snowflakes + bow		
MAKE IT MORE MODERN		Use one simplified character with flat graphic accents.	
MAKE IT MORE TRADITIONAL		Add patterned layers, scene-building pieces and soft texture.	

Christmas Card Style Library

Contemporary Graphic			
			
Overall feeling: Bold, current, energetic and design-led			
PALETTE	Unexpected pairings: navy/pink, teal/red, black/gold	IMAGERY	Oversized type, color blocks, abstract trees, geometric stars
TYPE	Bold sans serif, stacked words, high contrast	LAYOUT	Cropped forms, diagonals, grids and dramatic scale
MATERIALS	Clean cardstock, metallic accents, graphic patterns	GOOD FOLDS	Double Z-fold, bridge fold, diagonal gatefold
CLUSTER RECIPE	Largegeometric star + strips + tiny dots		
MAKE IT MORE MODERN		Increase scale, contrast and asymmetry.	
MAKE IT MORE TRADITIONAL		Bring in classic colors and a small natural motif.	

Handmade Layered Scrapbook			
			
Overall feeling: Personal, detailed, tactile and memory-filled			
PALETTE	Any coordinated collection; usually 4-6 colors	IMAGERY	Tags, labels, bows, snowflakes, stars, trees, bells, journaling
TYPE	Mixed fonts, die-cut titles and small labels	LAYOUT	Clusters in visual triangles; repeated colors and shapes
MATERIALS	Patterned papers, die cuts, ribbon, foam tape,GOOD stitching	FOLDS	Any special fold; especially joy, bridge and waterfall
CLUSTER RECIPE	Tag+focal icon + greenery + bow + three small accents		
MAKE IT MORE MODERN		Use fewer papers, cleaner edges and one strong cluster.	
MAKE IT MORE TRADITIONAL		Use more layers, inked edges, ribbon and multiple clusters.	

Mixing Styles Without Making a Mess

Mixed-style cards often feel the most personal. These secrets to let one style lead and use the second as an accent.

PAIRING	KEEP FROM STYLE 1	ADD FROM STYLE 2	RESULT
Traditional + Modern	Classic red/green and holly	Open space and clean type	Updated classic
Vintage + Minimal	One nostalgic focal image	Simple cream base and few layers	Quiet nostalgia
Rustic + Elegant	Kraft, pine and woodgrain	Gold foil and satin bow	Refined farmhouse
Nordic + Whimsical	Orderly folk pattern	Candy colors and playful scale	Cheerful handmade
Religious + Contemporary	Nativity or Bethlehem star	Bold scale and restrained palette	Modern reverence
Botanical + Luxe	Natural greenery and berries	Pearl, foil and symmetry	Elegant nature
Cute + Scrapbook Layered	One friendly character	Tags, patterned papers and accents	Storybook keepsake

The 70/30 rule

Let roughly 70 percent of the choices follow the leading style and 30 percent support the accent style. For example: traditional colors, imagery and ribbon can lead; modern spacing and typography can provide the update.

A dependable cluster recipe

- Choose one focal image: tree, bell, ornament, character or tag.
- Add one soft connector: bow, ribbon, greenery or layered paper.
- Add one contrasting shape: snowflake, star, circle or small label.
- Finish with three tiny accents in a visual triangle.
- Repeat at least one color or motif elsewhere on the card so the cluster belongs to the whole design.

Christmas Card Style Planner

Use this worksheet before cutting paper. It also works as a planning page for a cardmaking video.

CARD PURPOSE	Recipient / occasion: _____
LEADING STYLE	Traditional / Modern / Vintage / Rustic / Elegant / Whimsical / Other
ACCENT STYLE	_____
PALETTE	Main: _____ Support: _____ Metallic: _____
FOCAL IMAGE	_____
CLUSTER PIECES	Focal: _____ Connector: _____ Accent: _____
PAPER + TEXTURE	_____
TYPOGRAPHY	Serif / Script / Sans serif / Handwritten / Die-cut title
CARD FORMAT	Flat A2 / Gatefold / Easel / Z-fold / Bridge / Pop-up / Other
MODERN SIGNALS	Open space / Limited palette / Clean type / Bold scale / Asymmetry
TRADITIONAL SIGNALS	Classic color / Script / Symmetry / Ribbon / Layered cluster
VIDEO NOTE	Title idea: _____

Grandma's reminder

The best style is the one that supports the memory, message or person. Use these categories as helpful tools, not strict rules. A card can be traditional in color, modern in layout and completely personal in the details.